

Starfish, sea urchins, and sea cucumbers

Echinoderms are animals with bodies that are basically star-shaped, with a mouth in the middle. This five-rayed body plan is obvious in most starfish, but other echinoderms have it, too. They live in oceans throughout the world, where they prey on other animals, graze on seaweeds, or feed on the edible debris that settles on the seabed.

SPINY BALLS

The word echinoderm means “hedgehog skin.” This perfectly describes sea urchins, which are covered with spines. They have the same five-rayed body plan as most starfish, but formed into a ball, like an orange with five segments. They have long, flexible tube feet that they use for moving around and gathering food.



▲ BODY ARMOR

Slow-moving, sea urchins rely on their spines to deter predators. The spines often break easily, embedding themselves in the attacker's skin.

A starfish has no brain, but it does have simple eyes at the end of each arm.

SEA STARS

Most starfish have five arms extending from a central disc, but some starfish have as many as 50 arms. Like sea urchins, they have flexible tube feet, each ending in a tiny sucker. Many starfish feed on animals such as oysters, clamping onto their shells and pulling them apart to get at the meat inside.

▲ VIVID COLOR

Many starfish are brightly colored, with contrasting patterns of spines or plates on their skin. Their bright color helps warn predators that they may taste bad.

